

Lab Book

Bradley Day

2025-05-19

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Preface

This book details my research during the final year of my degree at the University of Bristol. Thank you to Professor Andrew Young for supervising and my project partner Jacob Taylor for his work.

This is a Quarto book.

To learn more about Quarto books visit <https://quarto.org/docs/books>.

Part I

Summer Reading

1 Work Done Over the Summer Break

Some reading and meetings occurred over the summer break prior to the start of the project, here I detail notes from meetings and will note key points from reading.

This project will be based on emission line fitting to the Iron $K\alpha$ emission line seen when looking at black holes. The focus will be on Active Galactic Nuclei (AGN).

Part II

Teaching Block 1

2 Week 1

2.1 2026/09/21

Lab book set up and initialised as a Github page. Meeting with supervisor arranged for 2026/09/22.

2.2 2026/09/22

Plans/questions for meeting:

- Confirm that Quarto is allowed for writing lab book
 - Yes
- Get connected to solva
 - This will need to be after Rhys has set things up
 - Note 2026-09-23 have connected to solva, however will wait until Rhys has given an induction to use
- Make sure GitHub set up properly so we can commit/push to it
- Confirm scope of project and form initial plan with Jacob
 - Fitting models?
 - * XSPEC?
 - * Julia (SpectralFitting.jl)?
 - * Other?
 - Data Reduction
 - * Using XMM-Newton data so will need to become familiar with [XMM SAS](#)
 - * Are we using this on solva?
 - * Note to self: see project plan on Github for more resources

2.2.1 Meeting Minutes

- XMM is not a survey telescope so even random selections will usually be interesting objects
- Andy will add a link to Nandra's paper on the Github repo for bright sources
 - Read this paper
- Browse paper(s) to find interesting sources
 - NGC4151?
 - Make sure to note when and how long observations were taken
 - HEASARC archive should let us search for particular objects
 - Download data and go through the ABC guide
- Before next meeting:
 - Look into candiadate AGN

- * Look at Tartarus database?
- Read papers provided by Andy
- Look through XMM SAS ABC guide

2.3 2026/09/23

2.3.1 Reading - K. Nandra (2007) [1]

- Covers 37 observations of 26 Seyfert galaxies from XMM-Newton
 - All show Iron K emission, which makes this paper useful for candidate selection for our research
 - Around 45% of the data was best fit with a relativistically blurred reflection model
 - * Some objects may not show the broadening?
- General background information
 - Iron line emission broadening predicted in Fabian et al (1989)
 - This was alongside the discovery that the emission likely comes from the accretion disk
 - Useful reads?
 - * Fabian (1989)
 - * George, Nandra & Fabian (1990)
 - * Tanaka et al. (1995)
- Data Reduction
 - They give a lot of detail on their data reduction which may be useful further down the line
 - Source taken from a circle with radius 700 detector pixels
 - There are several windowing modes on the CCD which will be important to note
- Model
 - They found that the minimum set of models was:
 - * Power law continuum (modelling the corona)
 - * Reflection model (e.g. XILLVER)
 - * Can use relativistic blurring on this however not necessarily needed
 - * Ionized absorber model
 - The models used are covered in depth, including how they selected if and how to apply the absorber models
 - * This will be useful later down the line to give some direction when fitting
 - They modelled the emission using a broad and narrow component, this may be useful to consider?
- Potential candidate list (from Figure 3 of Nandra et al.)
 - NGC3516(2)
 - * Very broad emission centred around the Fe K α line
 - NGC3783(2)
 - * Quite a clean spectrum with low noise/small errors
 - NGC4151(2) or NGC4151(3)
 - * Clean spectrum with broad emission

2.4 2026/09/26

2.4.1 Reading - Fabian et al. (2002) [2]

2.4.1.1 Background

- Presents preliminary results from a 325 ks observation of MCG-6-30-15
 - Data taken from both the EPIC MOS cameras and the EPIC pn camera in small window mode with a medium filter
- Very clear detection of a strong, broad, and skewed iron line
- Spectrum characterised well by a steep emissivity profile within $6r_g$ and a flatter profile beyond
- Inner radius of emission appears to lie around $2r_g$
 - This was measured from the fit, where the inner radius of the disc was a fitting parameter
 - The measurements are dependent on an assumed power-law continuum and lack of complex absorption above 2.5 keV
- ASCA observation showed emission from an accretion disc extending from $6 - 40r_g$ with an inclination of around 30°
 - Measured from Fe- $K\alpha$ line
- The red wing of the line extends below 4 keV which can be explained by the disc extending within $6 r_g$
 - Why is this??
 - This implies rapidly spinning black hole (as ISCO shrinks with a_*)

2.4.1.2 Fitting

- Several models were used to fit the data, including a phenomenological model (parameterising the iron line with power law, Compton reflection, a narrow Gaussian at 6.4 keV and a broad Gaussian which was free)
 - This provided a good overall fit with $\chi^2 = 984.1$ for 1034 degrees of freedom
 - * How are the number of dof determined?
 - This was improved by allowing the narrow Gaussian to have some width, giving an “excellent” fit
- Second model used the Laor (1991) emission line profile
 - Fits were insensitive to the outer radius of the disc, which was thus fixed at $400r_g$
 - Free parameters were R_{in} , the inclination, and the emissivity as a function of radius (parametrised as R^{-q})
 - Almost comparable χ^2 to the first model with two broad Gaussians
 - * This falls short as with a simple power law emissivity, the red wing and narrow core of the line cannot be modelled simultaneously
- Further improvements were made including
 - Addition of an iron K-edge
 - * The K-edge is a sudden increase in x-ray absorption [FIND CITATION FOR THIS, [wiki for now](#)]
 - * This significantly improved the fit
 - * The K-edge however must be explained physically, several attempts were made
 1. Neutral iron along the line of sight
 - This would require strong iron-L absorption, which is not present

2. Neutral iron outside the line of sight
 - Reflection off of distant material which would require strong reflection
 - This is inconsistent with the weak, narrow 6.4 keV iron line
 3. Thick material partially covering the line of sight
 - This gave a comparable fit to the edge
 4. Sako et al. (2002) suggested significant absorption due to inner-shell transitions of ionised iron
 - Explored using an absorption line model, giving a good fit
 5. The complexity around 7.0 keV is emission
 - Recombination emission by H-like iron
- * It was not possible to determine whether the complexity was due to absorption or emission and both were thus considered
 - Use of a broken power law
 - * This is not physically self-consistent
 - Ignores Fe $K\beta$ at 7.05 keV
 - The high EW is not consistent with $R_{\text{refl}} = 1$, $i = 30^\circ$, solar abundances and neutral
 - High abundance was investigated using $3\times$ the solar abundances which improved the fit significantly
 - Spectral variability was investigated by taking the ratio of the spectra resulting from two 10 ks intervals from the maximum and minimum flux periods
 - Taking the ratio of the two spectra showed clear signs
 - The iron line core is stronger in the low-flux spectrum
 - The models assume that the effects of ionized absorption are negligible above 2.5 keV, correct for absorption rising from low-Z elements, but may not be true if e.g. Si, S are present

3 Week 2

3.1 2026/09/29

3.1.1 First Investigations Into Data Reduction

- Can now use solva, and XMM-SAS is installed.
- Have got a script to automate the reduction thanks to Darius Michienzi
 - [GitHub](#)
 - This script is written in Julia so requires a Julia installation on solva
 - Currently running the command `julia` yields the error `-bash: julia: command not found`
 - Need to check with Rhys Morris whether Julia is installed, if so how can we access it, and if not whether we can install it
 - For now will proceed with manual reduction to learn the process, as the script may not cover all of our needs, so worth learning how it works under the hood
- Using the XMM-SAS ABC guide
 - Using dataset with OBSID 0761670101
 - Following instructions for EPIC (IMAGING Mode)
 - The first set of commands are `cd ODF` `setenv SAS_ODF /full/path/to/ODF/directory/` `setenv SAS_ODFPATH /full/path/to/ODF/directory/` `cifbuild`
 - This does not currently work, the `setenv` command seems to be for a `csh` shell, while solva uses `bash`
 - * This can be worked around by using e.g. `export SAS_ODF="/full/path/to/ODF/directory/"`
 - The `cifbuild` command also does not currently work, with the terminal giving the error that the command was not found

3.1.2 Meeting with Supervisor

- Questions
 - In Fabian et al. (2002) [2] it says that the red wing of the line extending below 4 keV can be explained by the disc extending within $6 r_g$
 - * Why is this?
 - * Is this just what their fit says?
 - Maybe start considering how we are going to fit the data?
 - * It may be possible to get a headstart setting up pipelines for it
 - * Discuss with Supervisor/Jacob if its worth using Julia (`SpectralFitting.jl`) or `xspect`?
 - Or something else?
 - * If using Julia, would it be worth designing our model?
 - Is there anything we can gain from this? More freedom in the parameters etc?

3.1.3 Meeting Minutes

- When fitting, will use XSPEC
 - Can create a table model if we need to use more abstract metrics etc.
 - Group working on catalogue of metrics have managed to get Gradus working for naked singularities (superspinning black holes)
 - * May be able to use this to fit non-standard descriptions to the data, and collaboratively investigate the cosmic censorship conjecture
- Downloading data from XMM-Newton Archive
 - Through legacy interface, create download script (gives `wget` script)
 - May be able to enter RA/DEC to find OBSIDs
- Meeting was successful with Andy's other group
 - They are working on cataloguing spacetimes and investigating the cosmic censorship conjecture
 - * This is the conjecture that naked singularities do not exist
 - * They may be able to compute iron line profiles with this, allowing us to fit this supposedly unphysical model to observations
 - * If doing this we will need to construct a table model for XSPEC
 - Groupchat set up with Fionn & Max which should allow us to compare notes and collaborate on issues

3.1.4 Misc Notes

- Recurring meeting set for 11:00 on Fridays with Jacob to keep each other in the loop and discuss issues

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Part III

Teaching Block 2

References

- [1] [K. Nandra *et al.*, Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society **382**, 194 \(2007\).](#)
- [2] [A. C. Fabian *et al.*, \(2002\).](#)